

Word family: **constant / constantly / constancy / inconstant**

Base word: constant

Related forms: constantly, constancy, inconstant, inconstancy

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / noun (名詞)

Your sentence:

> “The **constant clatter** of trays, background chatter and frequent interruptions are hardly conducive to serious concentration.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **constant** means **continuing or happening repeatedly with very little interruption, so that it seems to be present almost all the time**.

The trays may not literally make noise every single second. The writer means the clattering happens **so frequently and persistently that students cannot get sustained quiet**.

繁體中文： ** 持續不斷的；接連發生的；幾乎沒有停頓的

**中文翻譯： **

> “The **constant clatter** of trays...”

「托盤**持續不斷的碰撞聲**.....」

Here:

constant clatter = 不斷重複、令人一直受到干擾的碰撞聲

1. **constant = continuing or repeatedly happening with little interruption (持續) — 持續不斷的；頻繁而持久的**

This is the **exact passage sense**.

Practice 1 — Original

> “The **constant** noise makes concentration difficult.”

「**持續不斷的**噪音令人難以集中精神。」

Practice 2

> “She receives **constant** phone calls during the day.”

「她白天不斷收到電話，電話**接連不斷**。」

Practice 3

> “The machine needs **constant** attention.”

「這部機器需要**持續的**留意和照顧。」

constant = 某事持續存在，或非常頻繁地反覆發生，以致幾乎沒有明顯中斷

Common:

- * constant noise
- * constant interruptions
- * constant pressure
- * constant complaints
- * constant attention
- * constant reminders

2. **constant** = always present / regularly accompanying someone (一直存在) — 經常存在的；形影不離的

Something can be a **constant presence, companion, source, reminder**, etc.

Practice 4

> “Her dog was her **constant companion**.”

「她的狗一直是她**形影不離的伴侶**。」

Practice 5

> “Money was a **constant source** of worry.”

「金錢問題一直是她**長期的憂慮來源**。」

Practice 6

> “The scar was a **constant reminder** of the accident.”

「那道疤痕一直提醒着他那場意外。」

The concept is still:

> **something remains continually present in one's life or experience**

So I would keep this under Meaning 1 rather than split it.

3. **constant** = staying the same; not changing (不變) — 恆定的；不變的；固定的

This is the other major everyday/scientific adjective meaning.

Practice 7

> "Keep the temperature **constant**."

「把溫度保持在**恆定水平**。」

Practice 8

> "The car travelled at a **constant** speed."

「汽車以**固定速度**行駛。」

Practice 9

> "The pressure remained **constant** throughout the experiment."

「整個實驗期間，壓力保持**不變**。」

constant = 數值、狀態、速度、條件等維持同一水平，不隨時間改變

Common:

- * constant speed
- * constant temperature
- * constant pressure
- * constant rate
- * constant value

This is **different from the passage sense**.

Compare:

> **constant noise**

> = noise keeps happening

versus:

> **constant temperature**
> = temperature does not change.

4. **constant** = steadfast / faithful / unwavering (人 / 態度 , 正式) — 忠貞的 ; 堅定不移的

A more formal or literary meaning:

Practice 10

> “She remained **constant** in her support for him.”

「她對他的支持一直**堅定不移**。」

Practice 11

> “He was a **constant** and loyal friend.”

「他是一位**始終忠誠可靠**的朋友。」

constant = 在感情、支持、忠誠或信念方面不動搖、不改變

This develops from the “unchanging” sense but has a distinct human/emotional use.

Database status: genuine, but lower priority than #1 and #3.

5. **a constant** = fixed quantity/value (數學 / 科學) — 常數 ; 恆量

As a noun, **constant** has a major technical meaning.

A **constant** is a value or quantity that remains fixed rather than varying.

Practice 12

> “In this equation, 5 is a **constant**.”

「在這條方程式中，5 是一個**常數**。」

Practice 13

> “Scientists measured the physical **constant** very precisely.”

「科學家非常精確地測量這個物理**常數**。」

constant = 在某個數學、科學或技術系統中保持固定的量 / 值

Common:

* mathematical constant

* physical constant

* universal constant

* constant term

This is a major noun meaning and should definitely be separated from the adjective.

6. **physical constant** = physical quantity treated as universally fixed (物理) — 物理常數

Examples include quantities used throughout physics.

Practice 14

> “The calculation uses a fundamental physical **constant**.”

「這項計算使用一個基本的物理**常數**。」

This is a domain application of Meaning 5.

7. **constant of integration** (微積分) — 積分常數

In calculus:

> **constant of integration**

is the arbitrary constant usually written as **C** after indefinite integration.

Example:

> $\int 2x \, dx = x^2 + C$

Here **C** is the **constant of integration**.

繁體中文： **積分常數**

This is a useful mathematical compound, not a new core sense.

8. **rate constant / equilibrium constant (化學) — 速率常數 / 平衡常數**

In chemistry, **constant** appears in established technical terms such as:

- * rate constant
- * equilibrium constant
- * acid dissociation constant

These are specific numerical quantities in scientific models.

Again, these belong under the noun **fixed quantity/value** sense.

9. **time constant (工程 / 物理) — 時間常數**

In engineering and physics, a **time constant** characterizes how quickly a system responds or changes.

繁體中文： **時間常數**

A genuine specialist compound under Meaning 5.

10. **constant = value that should not change during program execution (電腦) — 常數**

In programming, a **constant** is a named or literal value intended not to change during execution.

Practice 15

> “The program stores the conversion factor as a **constant**.”

「程式把換算因子儲存為一個**常數**。」

The exact implementation differs between programming languages, but the concept is:

> **a value treated as fixed rather than variable**

This is a major computing extension of Meaning 5.

11. **constant function** (數學) — 常數函數

A **constant function** gives the same output regardless of the input.

For example:

> $f(x) = 5$

is a constant function.

Again, this develops from:

> **unchanging value**

Related form: **constantly**

Constantly most commonly means:

> continually or very frequently.

Practice 16

> “The children were **constantly** interrupting.”

「孩子們**不停地** / 老是在**打斷**別人。」

Practice 17

> “The technology is **constantly** changing.”

「科技正在**不斷地**變化。」

This second example is useful:

> **constantly changing**

does **not** mean “changing in an unchanging way.”

It means:

> **change keeps happening**

So **constantly** usually derives from Meaning 1 rather than Meaning 3.

Important nuance: **constantly** does not always mean literally every second

In everyday speech:

> “He’s constantly checking his phone.”

often means:

> **he checks it extremely frequently**

not necessarily:

> **without even one second of interruption**

This applies to your passage too:

> **constant clatter**

can mean **repeated, persistent clattering**, not necessarily one uninterrupted continuous sound.

Related form: **constancy**

Constancy means the quality of remaining stable, faithful, or unchanged.

Stability

Practice 18

> “The experiment depends on the **constancy** of the temperature.”

「這項實驗依賴溫度的**恆定性**。」

Faithfulness/steadfastness

> “She admired his **constancy**.”

「她欣賞他的**忠貞 / 堅定不移**。」

The second is more formal/literary.

Related form: **inconstant**

Inconstant means changing frequently or not remaining faithful/steady.

Examples:

> inconstant weather

> an inconstant lover

繁體中文：多變的；不穩定的；不忠貞的

This is genuine but considerably less common than:

* changeable

* unstable

* inconsistent

So it is lower priority.

Important distinction: **constant vs continuous**

This is especially important for your sentence.

continuous

means genuinely without interruption.

> continuous sound

= 聲音一直不中斷。

constant

can mean:

* continuous, or

* extremely frequent/repeated.

> constant interruptions

cannot literally be one uninterrupted interruption; it means interruptions happen repeatedly.

So **constant** is often broader than **continuous**.

Important distinction: **constant** vs **continual**

continual

usually means repeatedly happening, often with pauses between occurrences.

constant

can mean either repeatedly frequent or continuously present.

Compare:

> continual interruptions

> constant interruptions

Very close.

But:

> constant temperature

= fixed temperature.

> continual temperature ❌

does not work.

Important distinction: **constant** vs **consistent**

These are often confused.

constant

= does not change, or continues very frequently.

consistent

= behaves/follows a standard reliably and without contradiction.

> constant speed

> consistent performance

A student can perform **consistently well** even though the exact marks are not constant.

Important distinction: **constant vs stable**

stable

means not likely to change dramatically, collapse, or fluctuate.

constant

means actually remaining at essentially the same value/level.

> stable temperature

may fluctuate slightly.

> constant temperature

suggests it remains fixed.

Important distinction: **constant vs permanent**

permanent

means intended/expected to last indefinitely or not be temporary.

constant

means continually present or unchanging during the relevant period.

> permanent job

> constant noise

Noise can be constant for two hours without being permanent.

Important distinction: **constant vs persistent**

persistent

means continuing despite difficulty or repeatedly refusing to disappear.

It can carry a stronger sense of stubborn continuation.

> persistent cough

> constant noise

There is overlap, but **persistent** often implies:

> it keeps coming back / will not go away.

Important distinction: **constant** vs **incessant**

incessant

means seeming never to stop and often has a negative/emphatic tone.

> incessant chatter

constant

is more neutral.

> constant chatter

In your passage, **incessant clatter** would sound even more strongly critical.

Important distinction: **constant** vs **fixed**

fixed

means deliberately set or not variable.

constant

means remaining unchanged.

> fixed interest rate

> constant speed

They overlap in technical settings, but **fixed** often emphasizes deliberate setting/arrangement.

Grammar note: **constant + noun**

The noun determines which major sense is intended.

Repeated/continuous

- * constant noise
- * constant interruptions
- * constant pain
- * constant pressure

Unchanging

- * constant speed
- * constant temperature
- * constant value

So learners should not automatically translate every **constant** as the same Chinese word.

Grammar note: **remain/keep + constant**

A common technical structure:

- > remain constant
- > keep something constant

Practice 19

> “All other variables were kept **constant**.”

「所有其他變量都保持**不變**。」

This almost always uses the **unchanging** sense.

Grammar note: **constant in**

Formal steadfastness:

- > constant in one's support

> constant in one's affection

This is lower-frequency modern English.

Countability note

Adjective

No countability issue:

> constant noise

> constant temperature

Mathematical/scientific noun

Countable:

> a constant

> several constants

Examples:

> physical constants

> mathematical constants

Constancy

Usually uncountable:

> the constancy of the signal

Family-extension note

The practical family includes:

* **constant**

* **constantly**

* **constancy**

* **inconstant**

* **inconstancy**

Important constructions and technical compounds include:

- * constant noise
- * constant attention
- * constant reminder
- * constant speed
- * constant temperature
- * remain constant
- * keep constant
- * mathematical constant
- * physical constant
- * constant term
- * constant function
- * constant of integration
- * rate constant
- * equilibrium constant
- * time constant

The semantic network divides cleanly into two adjective concepts:

1. ****keeps happening / remains present****
2. ****does not change****

The technical noun ****constant**** then grows directly from #2.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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constant — continual/repeated	持續存在或非常頻繁地反覆發生，幾乎沒有明顯中斷
constant — ever-present	長期一直存在、陪伴或造成影響的
constant — unchanging	數值、狀態、速度等保持同一水平，不發生變化的
constant — steadfast	在忠誠、感情、支持或信念方面堅定不移的；較正式
a constant — maths/science	在特定數學 / 科學系統中保持固定的量或數值；常數
constant — computing	程式中被視為固定、不可隨意改變的值
constantly	不斷地；非常頻繁地
constancy	恆定性；亦可指忠貞、堅定
inconstant	多變、不穩定或不忠貞的；較低頻

For your original sentence

> “The ****constant clatter**** of trays...”

The exact meaning is:

****constant = 托盤碰撞聲持續存在或極為頻繁地反覆出現，使學生幾乎一直受到噪音干擾****

So:

> ****constant clatter****

= ****持續不斷 / 接連不斷的碰撞聲****

It does ****not**** mean:

> ****unchanging clatter****

The relevant contrast is:

> ****constant noise**** = noise keeps happening

> ****constant temperature**** = temperature does not change

For your database, I would count ****4 genuinely useful core meanings**** for ****constant****:

1. ****continuing/repeatedly happening with little interruption****
2. ****remaining unchanged or fixed****
3. ****noun: fixed value/quantity in mathematics, science, and computing****
4. ****steadfast/faithful/unwavering**** — genuine but lower-priority formal use

I would keep ****constantly**** and ****constancy**** as important family extensions, while treating mathematical compounds such as ****constant of integration****, ****physical constant****, and ****rate constant**** as domain realizations of the fixed-value noun rather than separate core meanings.